a story better left forgotten

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra knows. She knows from the moment she wakes up that something is wrong. No, not wrong – different. Good different. Everything is exactly as she has always wanted – and she needs to keep it that way.
(Or, inside the portal, from Catra's perspective)

Notes

I got an anon and now we're here. I got a DM of anons actually asking, requesting this over like two or three weeks and also specifically requesting I DON'T do this, which just encouraged me more.

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora does not sleep in.

And Catra does not wake up feeling like this. It is a weird day.

She wakes up at the foot of Adora's bed, like always. At the foot of Adora's big ass force captain bed. It feels *right*, having as much room to stretch out across the width of the bed as she would if she were sleeping across the length up by Adora's side.

Up by Adora's side. That is a thought. She could do that. They have always slept like this, with careful distance between them, but there is no one to see here in Adora's private quarters. She knows there is a reason, but in the morning haze she can't remember it. Something about Shadow Weaver getting mad about it? Catra does not know why she would, Shadow Weaver loves them both, but she does hate anything that deviates outside of horde guidelines. They are already *doing* that, though, with how Catra sprawls across the foot of Adora's bed despite her *official* assignment still being the bunkroom.

Catra sits up, stretching slowly. The Force Captain quarters are familiar, even if the decorations feel a bit off. A bit off from *what*, she does not know, but there is an odd dissonance in the room. Or maybe that is just Adora's snoring.

This is where she is meant to be. Everything feels *right,* despite the weirdness, as Catra crawls up the bed to loom over Adora, fully prepared to tickle her awake if need be. Moments like this are all Catra wanted, growing up.

I want it to stay like this forever, she thinks to herself. The next thought that comes is twisted, darker and angrier. *I have to keep things like this*.

Why would they change? Adora is Force Captain now, but she brought Catra *with* her. Nothing can pull them apart. Not now Adora has real power, not now they have *proven* themselves. Not now that

they are together on the battlefield and going to take Etheria by storm – likely a storm of fire and blood, but it will be glorious anyway .

Catra hesitates in waking Adora. She feels like she hasn't seen Adora this peaceful and relaxed in a long time.

She doesn't love you.

The thought comes from nowhere and nearly makes her drop down against Adora. She knows it with such *certainty*, despite all the signs to the contrary, all the gentle touches and the whispered discussion of, "You'll still sleep with me, right? After I'm captain and I'm in a different bed. I don't want a different bed if it means sleeping alone."

But Adora does not love her , and she *knows* it.

Cautiously, she calls Adora's name to wake her up.

--

Everything is perfect. Everything is right. This is just where they are meant to be.

Something still feels off. Catra jokes and laughs with Adora, elbowing her in the hall and taking her towards her surprise in the locker room, but all she can think is *don't leave me*. All she can think is *this is perfect* and *I have to protect us*.

Adora is being weird. Catra wonders if she feels it too. She keeps pausing, doing that weird little shutdown she does when something that breaks her perceived reality occurs. Usually she does it in the face of *Lonnie's favourite colour is pink* and not *here's what you did yesterday*, but every time she perks back up and remembers from the prompt Catra gives her. It still worries Catra.

She jokes about brain damage, but with every pause she can't help but feel that Adora knows this is wrong too, and she is not soothed by the *rightness* of it like Catra is. If she isn't, Catra will just have to cling to it for the both of them. This is *right* and she will do anything to keep things this way.

In the locker room, they laugh and wrestle and it is so perfect Catra does not question a thing. Shadow Weaver interrupts them, reaches for her, and for a reason she can't explain, she feels a momentary flash of panic. She tenses, but Shadow Weaver's touch is gentle and loving.

Everything is perfect – and then Shadow Weaver leads Adora away.

--

"*Catra, don't!*"

--

There is a gap, and then there is Adora, back again. With Catra. Where she *should* be.

Adora is a mess, handing her a blank note and insisting it *said* something. She is panting, confused and desperate. She knows this is wrong, but unlike Catra she is not *happy*. She should be happy. They have everything they have ever wanted, they have each other, why is that not *enough* for her?

The flash hits Catra, anger and betrayal and *belittled*, Adora dangling from a cliff, and Catra *doesn't help her*. Catra cuts her down.

In the present, Adora is still panicking, words running together , and Catra needs her to *stop*. Needs that vision to be gone, the fear to be gone, for the two of them to just be *okay* and be *happy* like they were that morning. She doesnt decide to slap Adora, but she feels an unknown wave of anger at her *ruining* this and she just needs her to stop. She is triggering something in Catra, something dark and hurt and twisted. She just wants them to be calm and happy again like they were this morning.

She tries to push it all down, to push it *away*. She takes Adora to their platform, where they have always been safe. Where it will feel *right* and Adora will stop panicking, and questioning, and *fighting her-*

It works. Adora is weird when they first get there, but she calms down. She listens to Catra, which may be a first. But she *questions* her to, she questions everything they want.

"What if we dont stay together? What if it all goes wrong?" she asks, and Catra's heart drops out of her chest.

It does all go wrong. It *did* all go wrong. But somehow they found their way back here where it is *right*.

"Why cant you see that?" Adora pleads, frustrated and confused as she looks at *nothing*.

Catra reaches for her, desperate. "Adora, stay with me, okay?" she asks. She has asked this before, she knows.

Adora didnt listen to her then, and she doesnt listen now .

Bonnie calls them down, tells them they are going to Salineas, and Adora *breaks*. She lists everything wrong, everything Catra can see but *doesn't care*. Catra grabs her, tries to snap her out of it, tries to bring her *home*.

Adora runs. Runs for *Scorpia*.

It is not the first time Catra has seen her retreating back.

--

Adora comes back, grabbing her and hauling her into a closet. She lists off names, names that mean nothing to Catra, she says *they're all gone* and Catra fights to remember, fights to keep Adora by her side. Adora wants them to leave, but Catra *doesn't want to*. She just wants this, the two of them, together again.

Because once, they were apart, and it nearly killed her.

"Everything's fine, okay?" she can hear the edge of doubt in her own voice. Adora is panicking, and Catra thinks in another life she would be worried by Adora panicking. She would ask her what is wrong and listen to her when she tells her. But in this life, Catra knows what is wrong, so she deflects and buries it. They could be *happy* if Adora would just *let them*.

"I know it's not perfect and *so do you*," Adora tells her, voice breaking.

The flashes hit her. The *memories*. The way things used to be – the way things *are*. Catra pushes them down, turns back around.

"You've gone crazy. I'm not going anywhere," she tells Adora, despite how she knows the truth. *Deny, deny, deny*. She just wants Adora, she just wants them *together*. Why doesn't Adora want that too?

Adora picks up the stun baton, and Catra barely gets a moment to react before things go black.

--

She wakes up in the skiff. She knows, she *knows*, but she won't let herself acknowledge it. Not until the fight, not until Adora begs her to *fix things*, not until the flashes overwhelm her, *break* her.

A part of Catra knew from the very first second, she just did not *care*. It was perfect, it was right, it was better than any outcome she had imagined. Better than more horde, better than the end of the world. She built the perfect world for Adora, gave her everything she had ever wanted – everything they had ever wanted – but Adora still didn't want *her*.

There is nothing left. *Nothing* that matters. Adora doesn't fucking love her, and there is no place in time or space that she can construct where Adora *will*. Adora always leaves, Adora always *fixes*, Adora always wins, and Catra is left alone in the dirt, a useless castoff who never accomplished anything. Who *no one* ever wanted, ever loved.

Catra fights her. She tries to *hurt* her. The way Adora hurt her, Adora destroyed her. She will never have her love, but she can't let her win now.

The world ends around them, and Catra falls. Despite everything, Adora reaches for her, looks at her with pleading eyes, begging her to do the right thing and be a good person. That is never something Catra could be.

Catra looks her in the eye, and she lets go. It is the last way she has left to hurt her.

--

She lands. She doesnt expect to, doesnt want to, but she lands on a chunk of earth and the corruption burns into her skin as she desperately climbs back up the side of the chasm. Adora is gone now, she thinks *Catra* is gone now. Catra hurt her, Catra *succeeded*.

But she can do more. Catra was never going to go out any way but clawing and scratching. Adora still *doesn't understand*. She still does not know how she hurt Catra, how she broke Catra, how she *drove* her to this. Adora does not understand that this is *all her fault*.

But she will.

--

Adora does not listen. She never *does*.

"Now live with it!"

They would not be here if Catra ever *could*.

--

There is nothing between Adora's face, hardened with anger as the punch comes flying at Catra, and when she wakes on the floor of Hordak's sanctum, thoughts clear again now she is free of the corruption but emotions *storming*.

She runs. Just like she always has. When she turns back to meet She-ra's eyes, they are as angry as Adora's had been. Her face is a

mask of anger, determination, retribution. Catra feels the shattered pieces of her heart disintegrate, fear gripping every limb. The look promises pain. The look promises revenge.

The look promises that whatever ceasefire they had between them, where they never tried to really *kill* the other – it is over now , for Adora. It promises that whatever lingering feelings Adora held for her are gone now.

That should be expected. Catra did try to destroy the entire world first - that includes Adora, even if the point had been that it included *herself*. She still feels her throat clench as she vanishes back into the shadows, into the darkness where she belongs.

Part of her heart says *if you loved me back, this never would have happened*. The rest of her heart betrays her . *No one could ever love you, you did this to yourself*.

And yet Catra still loves *her*.

One of them will die by the other's hand before this war is truly done. Catra, despite all her self-preservation and selfish desires, hopes it is *her*. She has been living in a world without Adora for long enough. She pulled that switch because she wanted it all to *stop*.

But Catra can't stop. Catra has to go out clawing and scratching. Catra has to *win*, to be worth *something*, to have some proof that even a moment of her suffering had a point if it accomplished something.

She will destroy herself, or the only one she loves will. She should have known it on the day Adora walked away, but she knows it now.

She doesn't love you. It never mattered if she did. Catra would still burn herself and the world down for her. She still *will*. It is all she has left. Everyone is gone, everyone has betrayed her. All she can do now is destroy.

End Notes

I'm really sorry , but I thought it and now you have to read it too.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!